

- Northern Army Command asked to identify eight battalions of Rashtriya Rifles to be deployed to combat Maoists.
- Decision was taken in May before the army commanders' conference.
- Will need approval from the Cabinet Committee on Security to move in.
- Air Force helicopters to assist in logistics. Army setting up sub-area headquarters in Jagdalpur.

WHAT ARE THE RASHTRIYA RIFLES?

Raised in 1990, the RR are specialised counter-insurgency troops. At present, there are 66 battalions, or six divisions, of around 75,000 soldiers. All RR units are deployed in Jammu and Kashmir in five sectors. They are infantry units and use no heavy weapons like armour and artillery. RR troops have a younger age profile. All personnel serve on deputation and draw higher pay.



A RASHTRIYA
RIFLES UNIT IN J&K

last resort and a final decision is likely to be taken by the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) chaired by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. The army plans to set up two sub-area headquarters in Jagdalpur and Ambarda on the Orissa-West Bengal border. These headquarters function as logistics bases for field formations and have also been used to direct counter-insurgency operations.

The key question is should the army be deployed? INDIA TODAY's Board of Experts on Security and Terror (BEST) was near unanimous in voting against it, arguing instead for the armed forces to be used only in support of the paramilitary forces in roles like training, logistics and surveillance. Essentially, upscaling the role they are already playing. The army has already trained 47,000 police and paramilitary personnel at its jungle warfare schools and Indian Air Force (IAF) pilots are flying four Mi-17 medium-lift choppers in transport missions in central India.

Yet, there is a certain context to the Government's decision to put the army

"We are examining all pros and cons and once a decision is taken, it will be binding on the army. It will accept the government's decision and implement it with vigour."

A. K. ANTONY
Defence Minister

